

Six new Co-Response Team locations announced to strengthen support for people in mental distress

Health New Zealand and NZ Police are expanding a joint response model that provides timely, coordinated support for people experiencing mental distress.

The next six locations for Health New Zealand and NZ Police Co-Response Teams have been confirmed, expanding a model that helps people experiencing mental distress receive timely, wraparound support that better meets their health needs.

The new teams will be established over the next three years in the Northland, Lakes, Hawke's Bay, MidCentral, Whanganui, and Nelson Marlborough health districts. The equivalent Police districts are Northland, Bay of Plenty, Eastern, Central and Tasman.

Co-Response Teams pair specialist mental health clinicians with frontline Police to respond together to mental health-related 111 calls, supporting a transition towards a multi-agency response for people experiencing mental distress.

Health NZ Director - Specialist Mental Health and Addictions Karla Bergquist says the new teams will help ensure people receive the right support from the right services at the right time.

“Having mental health specialists involved from the outset means people can be assessed earlier and connected with the care and support that is most appropriate for them. This may involve connecting them with community mental health services, arranging follow-up support or providing more immediate crisis support.”

Ms Bergquist says evidence from existing Co-Response Teams shows significant benefits.

“We know Co-Response Teams help people in distress and their family receive coordinated wraparound care. They reduce the need to use powers under the Mental Health Act and mean fewer people need to be taken to an emergency department or Police station.”

The next six locations include large rural areas where co-response requirements may differ from existing urban locations, Ms Bergquist says.

“We will work with our health and Police district teams to explore how a co-response model could work in these locations. Implementation planning will determine the most appropriate operating model based on the needs of these communities.”

The new locations were selected based on demand across Police and mental health services, community need, existing district alignment and the ability to support the ongoing operation of a dedicated Co-Response Team.

The expansion builds on four new Co-Response Teams in Auckland, Counties Manukau, Bay of Plenty and Canterbury announced earlier this year, and five existing teams in Waitematā, Waikato, Taranaki, Capital, Coast and Hutt Valley, and Southern.

Budget 2025 included \$10 million over four years to expand and support Co-Response Teams as part of a wider \$28 million package supporting a multi-agency response to mental distress-related 111 calls.

Assistant Commissioner Tusha Penny of NZ Police says Police are committed to working alongside Health NZ to deliver a safer and more effective response to mental health calls.

“Police attend thousands of mental health-related events each year, many of them non-criminal in nature. Working alongside mental health clinicians strengthens our response by bringing together clinical expertise and Police’s public safety role.”

“This partnership helps us provide earlier specialised support for people experiencing mental distress while delivering safer outcomes for individuals, their whānau and the wider community.”

“Police will always have a critical role where there is an immediate threat to life or safety, or where Police powers are required. By responding alongside clinicians, we are better equipped to assess situations, manage risk and connect people with the support they need.”